

Yale

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- A strong academic profile is required – competitive transcript (a high SAT score is a plus)
- A major component of the essays is **personality**. Have a defining experience(s) that has profoundly set you on your path. Preferably show an unknown element about you that isn't covered elsewhere in your app. Your **authentic story** will always set you apart. As Hannah Mendlowitz (Senior Assistant Director of Admissions at Yale) likes to put it, *"You don't have to be the world's most eloquent wordsmith to write a successful college essay; the best essays we read are those where the genuine voice of a highschool student (that's you!) comes through loud and clear and we really get a sense of who you are... I do have favorite essays that I can remember, but they have no particular topic in common. Instead, they're the ones where at the end I have a grasp on what it might be like to have a conversation with the writer, to be in the same room as them. This is what we mean when we talk about voice."*
- Use the short-response essays to demonstrate your fit at Yale: Be as quirky/nerdy/weird/serious as yourself. Give *'unfiltered'* responses, but be smart enough to not cross the line! Remain **authentic**.
- Convey that you intend to use your academic/non-academic interests for a greater cause (substantially helping people in your community/globally) by showing past initiatives ie. *giving free piano lessons, organizing borehole-drilling projects in arid areas, or starting a community library*. Establish a personal motivation to make the world a better place while embracing a global mindset in your essays.
- **Collaboration** over competitiveness is highly expected. The Residential Colleges try to foster a sense of community, so show that you are a team player (Avoid too many 'I's/individualism in your activities and essays). Let at least one of your recs positively back you up on your relationship with your classmates.
- Subtly hint at your **leadership** traits. Showing that you took initiative and founded something that has made a significant impact, is an advantage. Regardless, show that you are a leader who can collaborate in a group to bring change in a larger community.
- **ENERGY** and **PASSION** in your interests. Use your activities to portray that you are deeply into your extracurricular engagements and professional field(s) - having related honors is a boost. Demonstrate that you are likely to make the most of Yale's resources in those particular fields.
- **'And'** rather than **'Or'**. You don't need to define yourself as one thing. You could be a passionate dancer who is also a STEM major, or an artist who is also interested in Astrophysics. Find a way to thematically show that you're a multifaceted person - Paradoxical traits may be in high demand.
- Demonstrating an **interdisciplinary approach** to your course will give you an edge. Show that you're intellectually curious beyond the bounds of your field (Depth and

breadth). ie. *how studying Econ and Environmental Science might eradicate poverty and curb pollution in Kibera*. Do your research!

- Your ‘why major’ essay should show that you really know what you want to study, and how it will help solve global issues. Support your academic ambitions with personal experiences - stick to first-hand experiences as much as possible.
- Consequently, use the ‘why Yale’ essay to show how Yale will help you achieve those goals. Paint a clear picture of yourself at Yale (academically and socially). Again, research is vital!
- If you’ve made significant achievements in the **arts**, **SHOW IT!**
- Applying as an African (especially from Kenya) is **invaluable** at Yale. Play that card to your advantage!

NB: Always be **strategic** and **intentional** with everything you put in your app, and be aware how it reflects on your personality – tell them only what **YOU** want them to know about you.



To any interested applicant, all the hacks to submit a successful application are [here](#)! A comprehensive podcast by Yale Admissions Officers on the whole admission process, as well as what they ‘look for’ in applications.

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Go Bulldogs!